

“ I AM NOT A POLITICIAN, BUT A SOLDIER. ”

Idi Amin, in his first speech to the Ugandan nation, January 1971

IN UGANDA, GENERAL IDI AMIN SEIZED POWER from President Milton Obote in a **military coup** on January 25, while the president was out of the country attending the Commonwealth conference in Singapore (see 1979).

Sierra Leone, in West Africa, and **Qatar**, in the Middle East, formally achieved independence from Britain in this year.

In March, a **civil war** broke out between **Pakistan** and its dominion, **East Pakistan** (modern Bangladesh). Nearly nine million **refugees** fled to India. In December, Indian troops entered East Pakistan, following a **surprise attack on Indian airfields**. There was also heavy fighting in **Kashmir**. In a campaign lasting only 13 days, Indian troops crushed Pakistani forces in the east. On December 20, the independent state of **Bangladesh** was born (see 1972).

In **Northern Ireland**, the **Provisional IRA** stepped up its campaign against British security forces (see 1969). In August, the Northern Ireland government introduced **internment without trial** to stop the growing violence.

On September 15, a small team of activists set sail from Vancouver, Canada, on the ship *Phyllis Cormack* to protest against US nuclear tests in **Alaska**. They later adopted the name **Greenpeace**.

The **Walt Disney World** resort officially opened near Orlando in Florida on October 1. It featured Adventureland, Fantasyland, Frontierland, Liberty Square, and Tomorrowland.



IDI AMIN (1925–2003)

Idi Amin became known as the “Butcher of Uganda.” After seizing power in 1971, he ruled by terror—an estimated 300,000 people died during his reign. His behavior was both barbaric and eccentric: famously, he declared himself the “King of Scotland.” Idi Amin’s rule ended in 1979 after he was ousted by troops from neighboring Tanzania then forced to flee the country.

On October 25, **China’s admission to the UN** boosted the country’s international status. The US president, Richard Nixon (1913–94), sent his national security adviser, **Henry Kissinger** (b. 1923), to China for secret talks. Kissinger also began talks with the **USSR**, which led to a number of formal agreements, including one regarding **access to Berlin**.



British troops remove civil rights protestors from Londonderry, Northern Ireland, after the army opened fire on demonstrators during “Bloody Sunday.” Among the 13 civilians killed were seven teenagers.

BRITISH MINERS WALKED OUT ON NATIONAL STRIKE on January 9 after refusing a government pay offer. All 289 pits across the country were closed. On February 19, they agreed to a **new pay deal** and returned to work on February 25.

On January 30, British troops opened fire on demonstrators in **Londonderry**, Northern Ireland, **killing 13 people** and injuring 14. The marchers were protesting against the policy of internment without trial. This day came to be known as “**Bloody Sunday**.”

In the largest attack on mainland Britain since “**The Troubles**” (see 1966), the **IRA** bombed the 16th Parachute Brigade headquarters at Aldershot, Hampshire, on February 22, killing seven civilians.

President Nixon flew to China in February and met **Mao Zedong** (1893–1976), marking a new **cordiality in US–China relations**. In May, Nixon paid a state visit to **Moscow** to sign 10 agreements, the most important of which were the nuclear arms limitation treaties known as **SALT I**.

On June 8, South Vietnamese planes dropped a **napalm bomb** on **Trang Bang**, which was under North Vietnamese occupation. Napalm was an incendiary liquid that burned everything it touched. Images of **burned civilians** were shown around the world and increased pressure on the US to withdraw from Vietnam.

The prime ministers of India and Pakistan, **Indira Gandhi** (1917–84) and **Zulfikar Ali Bhutto** (1954–79), signed the **Simla Agreement** in July, in the wake of the 1971 war.

The agreement reiterated the promises for peaceful negotiations made in **Tashkent** (see 1966).

The terrorist group **Black September**, a faction of the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), took members of the **Israeli team** hostage during the **Summer Olympics** at Munich, West Germany. They later **killed**

11 athletes, launching a new era of international terrorism.

New horizons

For the Munich Olympics, leading artists made 35 posters, including the one shown below. Their aim was to erase the memory of the 1936 games, held during Hitler’s reign.



January 2 Crowd barriers collapse at Ibrox stadium, Glasgow, Scotland, killing 66 people

January 10 Death of Gabrielle “Coco” Chanel (b. 1883)

March 26 Civil War between East and West Pakistan

August 9 Northern Ireland government introduces policy of internment without trial

January 25 Idi Amin seizes power in Uganda

April 19 Sierra Leone becomes a republic

September 3 Qatar becomes a republic

September 11 Death of Nikita Khrushchev, former Soviet leader (b. 1894)

December 3 Pakistan attacks India

December India defeats Pakistan in 13-day war

December 20 Bangladesh born out of East Pakistan

January 13 Ghana becomes a dictatorship after military coup

January 25 First combined pancreas and kidney transplant performed at Guy’s Hospital, London

January 25 National Organ Matching and Distribution Service (NOMDS) founded in London

January 30 Paratroopers fire on protestors in Londonderry, Northern Ireland

March 25 British prime minister Edward Heath imposes direct rule over Northern Ireland

February 21 President Nixon visits China

May 29 Nixon and Brezhnev sign treaties reducing risks of nuclear war

July 2 Pakistan and India sign Simla Peace Agreement

August 26 Olympics open in Munich

December 25 Earthquake in Nicaraguan capital, Managua

August 6 Idi Amin expels 50,000 Asians with British passports

September 5 Israeli Olympic quarters stormed by Arab militants

November 7 Richard Nixon reelected as US president

December 26 Death of US statesman Harry Truman (b. 1884)